

The French Lumière brothers shoot the **46-second short** *La Sortie des usines Lumière à Lyon*.

↑  
**1894**

In **Charlie Chaplin's** second movie, *Kid Auto Races at Venice*, the character **the Tramp** appears for the first time.

↑  
**1914**

*The Cabinet of Dr. Caligari*, a disturbing **German Expressionist** classic, reflects its authors' experiences in World War I.

↑  
**1920**

F. W. Murnau's **unauthorized adaptation** of Bram Stoker's *Dracula*, titled *Nosferatu*, is released. It is nearly destroyed following a lawsuit.

↑  
**1922**

**1902**

↓  
Georges Méliès's *A Trip to the Moon* sets a new benchmark for high **production values** and **special effects**.

**1916**

↓  
D. W. Griffith's 3.5-hour epic *Intolerance* is an early **Hollywood blockbuster** movie.

**1920**

↓  
**Buster Keaton** stars in his first full-length comedy, *The Saphead*.

**1922**

↓  
*The Toll of the Sea* is the first **Technicolor movie** to be put out in general release.

**M**ovies are so much a part of today's culture that it is hard to imagine a time when they weren't there at all. It's hard, too, to appreciate the awe felt by the public of the 1890s at seeing moving pictures for the first time, as ghostly figures came to life before their eyes. From a 21st-century viewpoint, however, the real shock is how far those "movies" changed in the next three decades—quickly evolving into gorgeously vivid feature movies.

### Magic on screen

For the early filmmakers, there were no masters to learn from. Some had a background in theater, others in photography. Either way, they were breaking new ground, and none more so than Georges Méliès. As soon as this sometime magician

had begun entertaining the French public with movies, he looked for ways to make them more splendid and spectacular. In America, too, visionaries were at work. There, cinema thrived thanks to the likes of Edwin S. Porter, a former electrician who ended his 1903 feature *The Great Train Robbery* with a gunman turning toward the camera and appearing to fire at the audience.

Other filmmakers had grander plans. A few years later, Porter was approached by a fledgling playwright who hoped to sell him a script. Porter turned down the script, but hired the young man as an actor—and that same young man, the gifted and still controversial D. W. Griffith, later become a director himself, helping to father the modern blockbuster.

### Movies as art

Although the pioneers clustered in France and America, it was in Germany that the movies first became art. In the aftermath of World War I, a country mired in political and economic chaos gave rise to a string of masterpieces whose influence still echoes today. The silent era was filled with some of the most glorious, pristine filmmaking that cinema would ever know: the works of Robert Wiene, F. W. Murnau, and Fritz Lang. Yet even then, it wasn't just directors who deserved the credit—take the giant Karl Freund, a huge man with an equally vast knowledge of cameras, who would become a master cinematographer, strapping the camera to his body and setting it on bicycles to revolutionize how a movie could look.